

'Hi'm, that fixes it at between midnight and 3 A.M.'

'Exactly, and Madame Renaud's evidence places it at after 2 A.M. which narrows the field still further. Death must have been instantaneous, and naturally could not have been self-inflicted.'

Poirot nodded, and the commissary resumed:

'Madame Renaud was hastily freed from the cords that bound her by the horrified servants. She was in a terrible condition of weakness, almost unconscious from the pain of her bonds. It appears that two masked men entered the bedroom, gagged and bound her, whilst forcibly abducting her husband. This we know at second hand from the servants. On hearing the tragic news, she fell at once into an alarming state of agitation. On arrival, Dr Durand immediately prescribed a sedative, and we have not yet been able to question her. But without doubt she will awake more calm, and be equal to bearing the strain of the interrogation.'

The commissary paused.

'And the inmates of the house, monsieur?'

'There is old Françoise, the housekeeper, she lived for many years with the former owners of the Villa Geneviève. Then there are two young girls, sisters, Denise and Léonie Outlard. Their home is in Merlinville, and they come of the most respectable parents. Then there is the chauffeur whom M. Renaud brought over from England with him, but he is away on a holiday. Finally there are Madame Renaud and her son, M. Jack Renaud. He, too, is away from home at present.'

Poirot bowed his head. M. Hautet spoke:

'Marchaud!'

The *sergent de ville* appeared.

'Bring in the woman Françoise.'

The man saluted, and disappeared. In a moment or two, he returned, escorting the frightened Françoise.

'Your name is Françoise Arricher?'

'Yes, monsieur.'

'You have been a long time in service at the Villa Geneviève?'

'Eleven years with Madame la Vicomtesse. Then when she sold the Villa this spring, I consented to remain on with the English milor. Never did I imagine—'

The magistrate cut her short.

'Without doubt, without doubt. Now, Françoise, in this matter of the front door, whose business was it to fasten it at night?'

'Mine, monsieur. Always I saw to it myself.'

'And last night?'

'I fastened it as usual.'

'You are sure of that?'

'I swear it by the blessed saints, monsieur.'

'What time would that be?'

'The same time as usual, half-past ten, monsieur.'

'What about the rest of the household, had they gone up to bed?'

'Madame had retired some time before. Denise and Léonie went up with me. Monsieur was still in his study.'

'Then, if any one unfastened the door afterwards, it must have been M. Renaud himself?'

Françoise shrugged her broad shoulders.

'What should he do that for? With robbers and assassins passing every minute! A nice ideal. Monsieur was not an imbecile. It is not as though he had had to let *cette dame* out—'

The magistrate interrupted sharply:

'*Cette dame*? What lady do you mean?'

'Why, the lady who came to see him.'

'Had a lady been to see him that evening?'

'But yes, monsieur—and many other evenings as well.'

'Who was she? Did you know her?'

A rather cunning look spread over the woman's face. 'How should I know who it was?' she grumbled. 'I did not let her in last night.'

'Aha!' roared the examining magistrate, bringing his hand down with a bang on the table. 'You would trifle with the police, would you? I demand that you tell me at once the name of this woman who came to visit M. Renaud in the evenings.'

'The police—the police,' grumbled Françoise. 'Never did I think that I should be mixed up with the police. But I know well enough who she was. It was Madame Daubreuil.'

The commissary uttered an exclamation, and leaned forward as though in utter astonishment.

'Madame Daubreuil—from the Villa Marguerite just down the road?'

‘That is what I said, monsieur. Oh, she is a pretty one, *celle-là*!’ The old woman tossed her head scornfully.

‘Madame Daubreuil,’ murmured the commissary. ‘Impossible.’

‘*Voilà*,’ grumbled François. ‘That is all you get for telling the truth.’

‘Not at all,’ said the examining magistrate soothingly. ‘We were surprised, that is all. Madame Daubreuil then, and Monsieur Renaud, they were—’ he paused delicately. ‘Eh? It was that without doubt?’

‘How should I know? But what will you? Monsieur, he was *milor anglais*—*très riche*—and Madame Daubreuil, she was poor, that one—and *très chic* for all that she lives so quietly with her daughter. Not a doubt of it, she has had her history! She is no longer young, but *ma foi*! I who speak to you have seen the men’s heads turn after her as she goes down the street. Besides lately, she has had more money to spend—all the town knows it. The little economies, they are at an end.’ And François shook her head with an air of unalterable certainty.

M. Hautet stroked his beard reflectively.

‘And Madame Renaud?’ he asked at length. ‘How did she take this—friendship?’

François shrugged her shoulders.

‘She was always most amiable—most polite. One would say that she suspected nothing. But all the same, is it not so, the heart suffers, monsieur? Day by day, I have watched Madame grow paler and thinner. She was not the same woman who arrived here a month ago. Monsieur, too, has changed. He also has had his worries. One could see that he was on the brink of a crisis of the nerves. And who could wonder, with an affair conducted such a fashion? No reticence, no discretion. *Style anglais*, without doubt!’

I bounded indignantly in my seat, but the examining magistrate was continuing his questions, undistracted by side issues.

‘You say that M. Renaud had not let Madame Daubreuil out? Had she left, then?’

‘Yes, monsieur. I heard them come out of the study and go to the door. Monsieur said good night, and shut the door after her.’

‘What time was that?’

‘About twenty-five minutes after ten, monsieur.’

‘Do you know when M. Renaud went to bed?’

‘M. le juge, I propose to remain. I did not arrive in time to prevent my client’s death, but I feel myself bound in honour to discover the assassin.’ The magistrate bowed.

‘These sentiments do you honour. Also, without doubt, Madame Renaud will wish to retain your services. We are expecting M. Giraud from the Sûreté in Paris any moment, and I am sure that you and he will be able to give each other mutual assistance in your investigations. In the meantime, I hope that you will do me the honour to be present at my interrogations, and I need hardly say that if there is any assistance you require it is at your disposal.’

‘I thank you, monsieur. You will comprehend that at present I am completely in the dark. I know nothing whatever.’

M. Hautet nodded to the commissary, and the latter took up the tale: ‘This morning, the old servant François, on descending to start her work, found the front door ajar. Feeling a momentary alarm as to burglars, she looked into the dining-room, but seeing the silver was safe she thought no more about it, concluding that her master had, without doubt, risen early, and gone for a stroll.’

‘Pardon, monsieur, for interrupting, but was that a common practice of his?’

‘No, it was not, but old François has the common idea as regards the English—that they are mad, and liable to do the most unaccountable things at any moment! Going to call her mistress as usual, a younger maid, Léonie, was horrified to discover her gagged and bound, and almost at the same moment news was brought that M. Renaud’s body had been discovered, stone dead, stabbed in the back.’

‘Where?’

‘That is one of the most extraordinary features of the case. M. Poirot, the body was lying, face downwards, *in an open grave*.’

‘What?’

‘Yes. The pit was freshly dug—just a few yards outside the boundary of the Villa grounds.’

‘And he had been dead—how long?’

Dr Durand answered this.

‘I examined the body this morning at ten o’clock. Death must have taken place at least seven, and possibly ten hours previously.’

'And you say you have information to give which may assist us?'

'Possibly you know it already. You were aware that I had been sent for?'

'No. By whom?'

'The dead man. It seems he knew an attempt was going to be made on his life. Unfortunately he sent for me too late.'

'*Sacré tonnerre!*' ejaculated the Frenchman. 'So he foresaw his own murder? That upsets our theories considerably! But come inside.'

He held the gate open, and we commenced walking towards the house. M. Bex continued to talk:

'The examining magistrate, M. Hautet, must hear of this at once. He has just finished examining the scene of the crime and is about to begin his interrogations. A charming man. You will like him. Most sympathetic. Original in his methods, but an excellent judge.'

'When was the crime committed?' asked Poirot.

'The body was discovered this morning about nine o'clock. Madame Renaud's evidence, and that of the doctors goes to show that the death must have occurred about 2 A.M. But enter, I pray of you.'

We had arrived at the steps which led up to the front door of the Villa. In the hall another *sergent de ville* was sitting. He rose at sight of the commissary.

'Where is M. Hautet now?' inquired the latter.

'In the *salon*, monsieur.'

M. Bex opened a door to the left of the hall, and we passed in. M. Hautet and his clerk were sitting at a big round table. They looked up as we entered. The commissary introduced us, and explained our presence.

M. Hautet, the Judge d'Instruction, was a tall, gaunt man, with piercing dark eyes, and a neatly cut grey beard, which he had a habit of caressing as he talked. Standing by the mantelpiece was an elderly man, with slightly stooping shoulders, who was introduced to us as Dr Durand.

'Most extraordinary,' remarked M. Hautet, as the commissary finished speaking. 'You have the letter here, monsieur?'

Poirot handed it to him, and the magistrate read it.

'Hi'm. He speaks of a secret. What a pity he was not more explicit. We are much indebted to you, M. Poirot. I hope you will do us the honour of assisting us in our investigations. Or are you obliged to return to London?'

'I heard him come up about ten minutes after we did. The stair creaks so that one hears every one who goes up and down.'

'And that is all? You heard no sound of disturbance during the night?'

'Nothing whatever, monsieur.'

'Which of the servants came down the first in the morning?'

'I did, monsieur. At once I saw the door swinging open.'

'What about the other downstairs windows, were they all fastened?'

'Every one of them. There was nothing suspicious or out of place anywhere.'

'Good, Françoise, you can go.'

The old woman shuffled towards the door. On the threshold she looked back.

'I will tell you one thing, monsieur. That Madame Daubreuil she is a bad one! Oh, yes, one woman knows about another. She is a bad one, remember that.' And, shaking her head sagely, Françoise left the room.

'Léonie Oulard,' called the magistrate.

Léonie appeared dissolved in tears, and inclined to be hysterical. M. Hautet dealt with her adroitly. Her evidence was mainly concerned with the discovery of her mistress gagged and bound, of which she gave rather an exaggerated account. She, like Françoise, had heard nothing during the night.

Her sister, Denise, succeeded her. She agreed that her master had changed greatly of late.

'Every day he became more and more morose. He ate less. He was always depressed.' But Denise had her own theory. 'Without doubt it was the Mafia he had on his track! Two masked men—who else could it be? A terrible society that!'

'It is, of course, possible,' said the magistrate smoothly. 'Now, my girl, was it you who admitted Madame Daubreuil to the house last night?'

'Not *last* night, monsieur, the night before.'

'But Françoise has just told us that Madame Daubreuil was here last night?'

'No, monsieur. A lady *did* come to see M. Renaud last night, but it was not Madame Daubreuil.'

Surprised, the magistrate insisted, but the girl held firm. She knew Madame Daubreuil perfectly by sight. This lady was dark also, but shorter, and much younger. Nothing could shake her statement.

‘Had you ever seen this lady before?’

‘Never, monsieur.’ And then the girl added diffidently: ‘But I think she was English.’

‘English?’

‘Yes, monsieur. She asked for M. Renauld in quite good French, but the accent—one can always tell it, *n’est-ce pas?* Besides when they came out of the study they were speaking in English.’

‘Did you hear what they said? Could you understand it, I mean?’

‘Me, I speak the English very well,’ said Denise with pride. ‘The lady was speaking too fast for me to catch what she said, but I heard Monsieur’s last words as he opened the door for her.’ She paused, and then repeated carefully and laboriously:

“‘Yeas—yeas—but for Gaud’s sake go nauw!’”

‘Yes, yes, but for God’s sake go now!’ repeated the magistrate.

He dismissed Denise and, after a moment or two for consideration, recalled François. To her he propounded the question as to whether she had not made a mistake in fixing the night of Madame Daubreuil’s visit. François, however, proved unexpectedly obstinate. It was last night that Madame Daubreuil had come. Without a doubt it was she. Denise wished to make herself interesting, *voilà tout!* So she had cooked up this fine tale about a strange lady. Airing her knowledge of English too! Probably Monsieur had never spoken that sentence in English at all, and even if he had, it proved nothing, for Madame Daubreuil spoke English perfectly, and generally used that language when talking to M. and Madame Renauld. ‘You see, M. Jack, the son of Monsieur, was usually here, and he spoke the French very badly.’

The magistrate did not insist. Instead he inquired about the chauffeur, and learned that only yesterday, M. Renauld had declared that he was not likely to use the car, and that Masters might just as well take a holiday.

A perplexed frown was beginning to gather between Poirot’s eyes.

‘What is it?’ I whispered.

He shook his head impatiently, and asked a question:

Chapter 3

At the Villa Geneviève

IN a moment Poirot had leapt from the car, his eyes blazing with excitement. He caught the man by the shoulder.

‘What is that you say? Murdered? When? How?’

The *sergent de ville* drew himself up.

‘I cannot answer any questions, monsieur.’

‘True, I comprehend.’ Poirot reflected for a minute. ‘The Commissary of Police, he is without doubt within?’

‘Yes, monsieur.’

Poirot took out a card, and scribbled a few words on it.

‘*Voilà!* Will you have the goodness to see that this card is sent in to the commissary at once?’

The man took it and, turning his head over his shoulder, whistled. In a few seconds a comrade joined him and was handed Poirot’s message. There was a wait of some minutes, and then a short stout man with a huge moustache came bustling down to the gate. The *sergent de ville* saluted and stood aside.

‘My dear M. Poirot,’ cried the new-comer, ‘I am delighted to see you.

Your arrival is most opportune.’

Poirot’s face had lighted up.

‘M. Bex! This is indeed a pleasure.’ He turned to me. ‘This is an English friend of mine, Captain Hastings—M. Lucien Bex.’

The commissary and I bowed to each other ceremoniously, then M. Bex turned once more to Poirot.

‘*Mon vieux*, I have not seen you since 1909, that time in Ostend. I heard that you had left the Force?’

‘So I have. I run a private business in London.’

The chauffeur thanked him, and started the car again. My eyes were fascinated by the girl who still stood, with one hand on the gate, watching us. I am an admirer of beauty, and here was one whom nobody could have passed without remark. Very tall, with the proportions of a young goddess, her uncovered golden head gleaming in the sunlight, I swore to myself that she was one of the most beautiful girls I had ever seen. As we swung up the rough road, I turned my head to look after her.

'By Jove, Poirot,' I exclaimed, 'did you see that young goddess?'

Poirot raised his eyebrows.

'*Ça commence!*' he murmured. 'Already you have seen a goddess!'

'But, hang it all, wasn't she?'

'Possibly. I did not remark the fact.'

'Surely you noticed her?'

'*Mon ami*, two people rarely see the same thing. You, for instance, saw a goddess. I—' he hesitated.

'Yes?'

'I saw only a girl with anxious eyes,' said Poirot gravely.

But at that moment we drew up at a big green gate, and, simultaneously, we both uttered an exclamation. Before it stood an imposing *sergent de ville*. He held up his hand to bar our way.

'You cannot pass, messieurs.'

'But we wish to see Mr Renaud,' I cried. 'We have an appointment.'

'This is his Villa, isn't it?'

'Yes, monsieur, but—'

Poirot leaned forward.

'But what?'

'M. Renaud was murdered this morning.'

'Pardon, M. Bex, but without doubt M. Renaud could drive the car himself?'

The commissary looked over at Frangoise, and the old woman replied promptly:

'No, Monsieur did not drive himself.'

Poirot's frown deepened.

'I wish you would tell me what is worrying you,' I said impatiently.

'See you not? In his letter M. Renaud speaks of sending the car for me to Calais.'

'Perhaps he meant a hired car,' I suggested.

'Doubtless that is so. But why hire a car when you have one of your own. Why choose yesterday to send away the chauffeur on a holiday—suddenly, at a moment's notice? Was it that for some reason he wanted him out of the way before we arrived?'

‘For you, yes. For me, I have work to do, remember, at our journey’s end.’

‘Bah!’ I said cheerfully. ‘You will discover all, ensure this Mr Renault’s safety, run the would-be assassins to earth, and all will finish in a blaze of glory.’

‘You are sanguine, my friend.’

‘Yes, I feel absolutely assured of success. Are you not the one and only Hercule Poirot?’

But my little friend did not rise to the bait. He was observing me gravely.

‘You are what the Scotch people call “fey,” Hastings. It presages disaster.’

‘Nonsense. At any rate, you do not share my feelings.’

‘No, but I am afraid.’

‘Afraid of what?’

‘I do not know. But I have a premonition—*a je ne sais quoi!*’

He spoke so gravely, that I was impressed in spite of myself.

‘I have a feeling,’ he said slowly, ‘that this is going to be a big affair—a long, troublesome problem that will not be easy to work out.’

I would have questioned him further, but we were just coming into the little town of Merlinville, and we slowed up to inquire the way to the Villa Geneviève.

‘Straight on, monsieur, through the town. The Villa Geneviève is about half a mile the other side. You cannot miss it. A big Villa, overlooking the sea.’

We thanked our informant, and drove on, leaving the town behind. A fork in the road brought us to a second halt. A peasant was trudging towards us, and we waited for him to come up to us in order to ask the way again. There was a tiny Villa standing right by the road, but it was too small and dilapidated to be the one we wanted. As we waited, the gate of it swung open and a girl came out.

The peasant was passing us now, and the driver leaned forward from his seat and asked for direction.

‘The Villa Geneviève? Just a few steps up this road to the right, monsieur. You could see it if it were not for the curve.’

In spite of myself I laughed immoderately. Poirot nodded in a satisfied manner.

‘So. You leave the work of the d— hounds to the hounds. Yet you demand that I, Hercule Poirot, should make myself ridiculous by lying down (possibly on damp grass) to study hypothetical footprints, and should scoop up cigarette ash when I do not know one kind from the other. Remember the Plymouth Express mystery. The good Japp departed to make a survey of the railway line. When he returned, I, without having moved from my apartments, was able to tell him exactly what he had found.’

‘So you are of the opinion that Japp wasted his time.’

‘Not at all, since his evidence confirmed my theory. But *I* should have wasted my time if *I* had gone. It is the same with so called “experts.” Remember the handwriting testimony in the Cavendish Case. One counsel’s questioning brings out testimony as to the resemblances, the defence brings evidence to show dissimilarity. All the language is very technical. And the result? What we all knew in the first place. The writing was very like that of John Cavendish. And the psychological mind is faced with the question “Why?” Because it was actually his? Or because some one wished us to think it was his? I answered that question, *mon ami*, and answered it correctly.’

And Poirot, having effectually silenced, if not convinced me, leaned back with a satisfied air.

On the boat, I knew better than to disturb my friend’s solitude. The weather was gorgeous, and the sea as smooth as the proverbial mill-pond, so I was hardly surprised to hear that Laverguier’s method had once more justified itself when a smiling Poirot joined me on disembarking at Calais. A disappointment was in store for us, as no car had been sent to meet us, but Poirot put this down to his telegram having been delayed in transit.

‘Since it is *carte blanche*, we will hire a car,’ he said cheerfully. And a few minutes later saw us creaking and jolting along, in the most ramshackle of automobiles that ever plied for hire, in the direction of Merliville.

My spirits were at their highest.

‘What gorgeous air!’ I exclaimed. ‘This promises to be a delightful trip.’

Chapter 4

The Letter Signed ‘Bella’

FRANÇOISE had left the room. The magistrate was drumming thoughtfully on the table.

‘M. Bex,’ he said at length, ‘here we have directly conflicting testimony. Which are we to believe, Françoise or Denise?’

‘Denise,’ said the commissary decidedly. ‘It was she who let the visitor in. Françoise is old and obstinate, and has evidently taken a dislike to Madame Daubreuil. Besides, our own knowledge tends to show that Renauld was entangled with another woman.’

‘*Tiens!*’ cried M. Hauter. ‘We have forgotten to inform M. Poirot of that.’ He searched amongst the papers on the table, and finally handed the one he was in search of to my friend. ‘This letter, M. Poirot, we found in the pocket of the dead man’s overcoat.’

Poirot took it and unfolded it. It was somewhat worn and crumpled, and was written in English in a rather unformed hand:

My dearest one:

Why have you not written for so long? You do love me still, don’t you? Your letters lately have been so different, cold and strange, and now this long silence. It makes me afraid. If you were to stop loving me! But that’s impossible—what a silly kid I am—always imagining things! But if you *did* stop loving me, I don’t know what I should do—kill myself perhaps! I couldn’t live without you. Sometimes I fancy another woman is coming between us. Let her look out, that’s all—and you too! I’d as soon kill you as let her have you! I mean it.

But there, I'm writing high-flown nonsense. You love me, and I love you—yes, love you, love you, love you!

Your own adoring

BELLA.

There was no address or date. Poirot handed it back with a grave face. 'And the assumption is, M. le juge—?'

The examining magistrate shrugged his shoulders.

'Obviously M. Renauld was entangled with this Englishwoman—Bella. He comes over here, meets Madame Daubreuil, and starts an intrigue with her. He cools off to the other, and she instantly suspects something. This letter contains a distinct threat. M. Poirot, at first sight the case seemed simplicity itself. Jealousy! The fact that M. Renauld was stabbed in the back seemed to point distinctly to its being a woman's crime.'

Poirot nodded.

'The stab in the back, yes—but not the gravel! That was laborious work, hard work—no woman dug that grave, monsieur. That was a man's doing.'

The commissary exclaimed excitedly: 'Yes, yes, you are right. We did not think of that.'

'As I said,' continued M. Hautec, 'at first sight the case seemed simple, but the masked men, and the letter you received from M. Renauld complicate matters. Here we seem to have an entirely different set of circumstances, with no relationship between the two. As regards the letter written to yourself, do you think it is possible that it referred in any way to this "Bella," and her threats?'

Poirot shook his head.

'Hardly. A man like M. Renauld, who has led an adventurous life in out-of-the-way places, would not be likely to ask for protection against a woman.'

The examining magistrate nodded his head emphatically.

'My view exactly. Then we must look for the explanation of the letter—'

My friend, who was anxiously scanning the weather, turned a reproachful face upon me.

'Is it that you have forgotten the method most excellent of Laverguier? His system, I practise it always. One balances oneself, if you remember, turning the head from left to right, breathing in and out, counting six between each breath.'

'H'm,' I demurred. 'You'll be rather tired of balancing yourself and counting six by the time you get to Santiago, or Buenos Ayres, or wherever it is you land.'

'*Quelle idée!* You do not figure to yourself that I shall go to Santiago?'

'Mr Renauld suggests it in his letter.'

'He did not know the methods of Hercule Poirot. I do not run to and fro, making journeys, and agitating myself. My work is done from within—*here*—' he tapped his forehead significantly.

As usual, this remark roused my argumentative faculty.

'It's all very well, Poirot, but I think you are falling into the habit of despising certain things too much. A finger-print has led sometimes to the arrest and conviction of a murderer.'

'And has, without doubt, hanged more than one innocent man,' remarked Poirot dryly.

'But surely the study of finger-prints and footprints, cigarette ash, different kinds of mud, and other clues that comprise the minute observation of details—all these are of vital importance?'

'But certainly. I have never said otherwise. The trained observer, the expert, without doubt he is useful! But the others, the Hercules Poirots, they are above the experts! To them the experts bring the facts, their business is the method of the crime, its logical deduction, the proper sequence and order of the facts; above all, the true psychology of the case. You have hunted the fox, yes?'

'I have hunted a bit, now and again,' I said, rather bewildered by this abrupt change of subject. 'Why?'

'*Eh bien*, this hunting of the fox, you need the dogs, no?'

'Hounds,' I corrected gently. 'Yes, of course.'

'But yet,' Poirot wagged his finger at me. 'You did not descend from your horse and run along the ground smelling with your nose and uttering loud Ow Ows?'